Front: one-screen check

Five visible items

Purpose
Context
Ask
Reply path
Deadline or next step

Minimum viable move

Quick ask + one context line + clear response path.

Field test

Could a reasonable reader answer correctly from the first screen? If not, move the ask up, shorten context, or add a reply path.

Example

Decision needed today: choose A keep Friday launch with reduced scope, or B move launch to Tuesday with full scope.
Reply A or B by 4 pm.

Safety

Clarity is not pressure. Add autonomy, context or a full document when the stakes require it.

Back: recovery and neighbour map

Recovery

I made that too dense.
I buried the ask.
I compressed that too much.
I was aiming for clarity, not pressure.

Neighbour map

BLUF: bottom line first.
Clean request: exact ask.
Low-friction ask: easier action.
TC088: whole message usability.

Adjust when

The reader asks what you need.
They respond to background, not the action.
They sound wary, rushed or under-informed.

Avoid when

Sensitive repair needs care.
Legal or safety detail matters.
A short message would hide trade-offs.

Field tip

Write the first screen as if it is the only screen they will read - because often it is.